‘I will monitor your project, and you can interact with me anytime you want to,’ he said, ‘but the administrative hierarchy should remain in place.’

I got the message.

Dhawan and Brahm Prakash appeared to be satisfied that they could drive some sense into me, and stop me from quitting. They obviously wanted me to believe that by postponing this discussion from the previous night, they had given me time to cool down and think. That was true. But it was equally true that they wanted time for themselves to placate me with a new idea and retain me.

I was finishing my bread and fried eggs when Dhawan cleared his throat. ‘Now, with your permission,’ he said, taking out the resignation letter I had given him the previous night, ‘May I do the honours?’

He tore the letter and threw it into the bin.

* * *

We soon did three more ground tests—two short duration and one long duration—which were successful. The first test flight, however, was a failure. An analysis showed that it was because of ‘combined beating and sloshing’, a phenomenon little-known to us then. In simple terms, ‘combined beating and sloshing’ is similar to the movement of water in a tanker on the move. Liquid fuel, while flying, would beat and slosh, resulting in variations in flow, thereby upsetting our calculations. Later we developed methods to minimise, if not prevent, these anomalies.

A year later, after I left for Vernon to head a team of sixty-odd Indian scientists to work in collaboration with the French to develop the Viking-Vikas engine, the three-tonner was successfully flown twice by a team comprising my colleagues A Chandran, D Subramanyam, M K Narendranath, D Anandan, Mohammed Muslim and O P Varshney.

In the absence of a project, the three-tonne engine was abandoned. It was anyway a technology demonstration project.